The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Oil prices surged dramatically when markets opened in Asia as traders reacted to the war in Iran that began over the weekend. Brent crude, the global benchmark, jumped to $82 a barrel, from $73 on Friday. European diesel futures rose by 10% to their highest level in two years. Wood Mackenzie, a research firm, reckons oil prices could surpass $100 if conflict around the Persian Gulf continues.

Donald Trump plans to speak with **Iran's** new leadership, according to comments he gave to the *Atlantic* magazine. "They want to talk," he said, though declined to say when a conversation would happen. An interim three-person panel, formed on Sunday, has replaced Ali Khamenei, the supreme leader killed by American and Israeli strikes. The "**leadership council**" consists of Masoud Pezeshkian, the president; Gholam-Hossein Mohseni-Ejei, the head of the judiciary; and Alireza Arafi, a high-ranking cleric.

America's armed forces said three service members have been killed and five seriously wounded. They did not say where or how, but denied Iranian reports that missiles launched at the *USS Abraham Lincoln* hit the aircraft-carrier, saying the strikes did not "even come close". Mr Trump said American forces had sunk nine

Iranian navy ships and “largely destroyed” Iran’s naval headquarters.

Iran continued its retaliatory strikes on other countries in the region. They fired missiles and drones across Israel and at Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar, where America has military bases. Most were intercepted. But one hit a bomb shelter near **Jerusalem**, killing at least nine people. Israel, meanwhile, launched more air strikes targeting “the heart” of **Tehran**, Iran’s capital.

Hundreds of thousands of **air passengers** were stranded as carriers cancelled flights across the Middle East. Connecting airports, including in Abu Dhabi, Dubai and Doha, grounded all services. Airlines also diverted planes from the region. Meanwhile Iran’s navy is reportedly telling ships they are not allowed to use the **Strait of Hormuz**, a waterway through which a third of all seaborne oil travels.

In other news: A gunman in **Austin, Texas** killed two people and injured 14 at a bar. The FBI said it was investigating a potential connection to terrorism. **María Corina Machado**, Venezuela’s opposition leader, said she will return to the country in the coming weeks. And 10 people died in **Karachi, Pakistan** after protesters supportive of Iran’s regime clashed with security forces outside an American consulate.

Photograph: USS Abraham Lincoln (CVN 72)

What will America and Israel strike next?

The range of targets that America and Israel have hit since they began attacking Iran on Saturday has been wide. But the most important bomb was the one that killed Ali Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader. After his death, the list of targets is likely to change. In the coming hours and days America and Israel will go through a process known as "battle-damage assessment" to work out what they have destroyed, whom they have killed and which sites might need follow-up bombing.

Both countries will try to hit Iranian missile-launchers as they emerge from hidden positions, with the aim of pre-empting salvoes. If Iran succeeds in killing American personnel at military bases in the Persian Gulf, Donald Trump could intensify his campaign in response. Despite the uncertainty at the top of the Islamic regime, many days of war may still lie ahead.

Photograph: Getty Images

The threat to Gulf states

Iran wasted little time before lashing out at its Arab neighbours on Saturday. It fired missiles and drones at military bases in Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, all of which host American troops. Most of the attacks were swatted away by air defences. It caused more damage to civilian targets: drones hit Kuwait’s international airport and a residential tower in Bahrain; a luxury hotel in Dubai was set ablaze.

Gulf rulers had spent the past two months trying to convince Donald Trump not to strike Iran, fearing exactly this sort of retaliation. Oman tried to mediate talks over a nuclear deal that would prevent war. Those efforts failed. They are desperate to avoid a prolonged war, which could shatter their reputation as safe hubs for business and tourism. Some firms are already drawing up plans in case they have to evacuate staff. Yet the harder Iran hits Gulf states, the more it may end up pushing them into alignment with America.

Photograph: Imago

The war’s impact on energy prices

Speculation about oil prices began as soon as America first struck Iran on Saturday, and for good reason. Iran produces about 3% of the world’s oil. Even more importantly, the country sits just next to the Strait of Hormuz—the narrow waterway to the Persian Gulf along which roughly a third of all seaborne oil travels. Accounts of explosions at Iran’s main oil-export terminal were rapidly followed by reports that Iran’s navy was stopping ships passing through the strait. Analysts predicted that the price of a barrel of Brent crude—the international benchmark, which had cost $73 on Friday—would rapidly rise above $80.

They were proved right within seconds of Asian markets reopening on Monday morning: the price of Brent jumped by roughly 10%. An announcement earlier in the day that the Organisation of the Petroleum Producing Countries and its partners intended to increase production elsewhere in April made little difference. The longer the conflict drags on, the greater the impact on energy markets will be.

I’m glad you like adverbs — I adore them; they are the only qualifications I really much respect.

Henry James